

Quasi-names in Akan: A further piece of the definiteness puzzle¹

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Abstract. This paper provides an analysis of definite bare nouns in Akan as quasi-names – nouns which, like *Mum* in English, can be used as names but are associated with descriptive content (Yip et al., 2023). The paper also provides further evidence that the Akan definite *no* is used in typical uniqueness contexts. Taken together, the data are consistent with an analysis of *no* as a uniqueness definite, whose reduced distribution can be explained by competition with the bare noun, analysed as a quasi-name (Bombi, 2018; Bombi et al., 2019).

Keywords: definiteness, Akan, bare nouns, quasi-names, proper names, honorifics.

1. Introduction

This paper revisits the question of how definiteness is expressed in Akan. To date, the discussion centered around the definite article *no*, specifically on whether it should be analysed as a familiarity definite, a uniqueness definite, or a different category altogether. The debate was framed within the larger question of how definiteness is expressed across languages, and whether Akan should be integrated into current definiteness typologies (Arkoh and Matthewson, 2013; Bombi, 2018; Owusu, 2022, 2025; Coppock, 2022; Dayal, 2023). Though crucial for this debate, less attention was paid to the definite bare noun, whose exact distribution remains disputed.

Addressing this issue, the present paper re-examines Akan definite bare nouns, and proposes that at least some of them are quasi-names – proper names associated with descriptive content, similar to *Mum* and *Dad* in English (Pelczar and Rainsbury, 1998; Yip et al., 2023). The proposal is supported by two properties: the requirement that there be a particular relation between the interlocutors and the referent (*Mum* is usually the interlocutors’ mother), and lexical restrictions (not all nouns can be bare and definite). At the same time, Akan quasi-names do not seem to take obligatory wide scope, contrary to previous descriptions of the phenomenon. The paper sheds new light on the distribution of Akan bare nouns, and partly explains the reduced distribution of the definite *no*, which competes with the “bare” quasi-names in larger uniqueness.

The paper is structured as follows. Section 2 surveys the previous literature on Akan definiteness. Section 3 presents the main data supporting the quasi-name account, whose analysis is presented in Section 4. In Section 5, we elaborate on different aspects of the theory of quasi-names – including the competition with the definite, potential sources of quasi-names, non-human quasi-names, and connections to other phenomena. Section 6 briefly concludes.

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2. Background: Definiteness in Akan

Akan (Kwa, Niger-Congo) has been at the center of a heated debate on definiteness typology. The main focus of this debate was the definite *no* and its alternation with other definite forms, namely the bare noun and the (distal) demonstrative *saa...no*.

It is worth noting that, despite theoretical disagreements, there is broad consensus on the basic distribution of these forms, summarised in (1) (cf. discussion in Arkoh and Matthewson, 2013; Bombi, 2018; Bombi et al., 2019; Owusu, 2022; Owusu, 2025).

(1) *Distribution of Akan definites (terminology from Hawkins, 1978)*

	Deixis	Anaphora	Immediate situation	Larger/Global situation
<i>saa...no</i> (DEM.DIST)	✓	✓	✓	✗
<i>no</i> (DEF)	✗	✓	✓	?✓
∅ (bare noun)	✗	✗	✗	?✓

One uncontroversial generalisation is that *no* is possible in anaphora, whereas the bare noun is not, cf. (2). It is also generally agreed that *no* requires some notion of uniqueness: it is felicitous when there is one dress, but not when there are several, (3); and it is not available in typical deixis examples such as (4).

- (2) Ama hu-u *abrantee bi*. **Abrantee no** / #**Abrantee** kyea-a Ama.
 Ama see-PST young.man INDF young.man DEF young.man greet-PST Ama
 ‘Ama saw a boy. The boy greeted Ama.’ (anaphora)
- (3) a. (Kofi and Ama are at the market. Ama comes back with one dress. K. says:)
 Me-pe **ataade no**.
 1SG-like dress DEF
 ‘I like the dress.’ (immediate situation)
- b. (Kofi and Ama are at the market. Ama comes back with several dresses. Kofi says:)
 ⇒ *no* is not possible (no uniqueness)
- (4) #Me-pe **car no**₁ nanso me-m-pe **car no**₂.
 1SG-like car DEF but 1SG-NEG-like car DEF
 ‘I like the car but I don’t like the car.’ (Pointing at two different cars) (deixis)

However, it is disputed to what extent *no* is possible in larger and global uniqueness – arguably, the most prototypical uniqueness contexts. Here, the bare noun is (also) licensed, and the precise distribution of each of the two forms is contested. On the one hand, Arkoh and Matthewson (2013) and Owusu (2022, 2025) present the bare noun as obligatory, cf. (5). On the other, Bombi (2018) and Bombi et al. (2019) observe that *no* is possible in these contexts, cf. (6).

Quasi-names in Akan

- (5) (Beginning of a documentary on the solar system)
Awia (***no**) yɛ nsoroma.
 sun DEF COP star
 ‘The sun is a star.’ (Owusu, 2022: 43)
- (6) (There is a new teacher at a school. A colleague explains how everything works [...])
Headmaster (**no**) bɛ-ma wo timetable.
 headmaster DEF FUT-give you timetable
 ‘The headmaster will give you your timetable.’ (Bombi, 2018: 155)

To sum up, the definite *no* broadly parallels the behaviour of *the*, although some of its functional space is taken up by the bare noun. It is the last point that remains a source of disagreement, specifically whether the bare noun is the default option in larger uniqueness or not.

Coupled with diverging theoretical assumptions, this has led to two broad views on the Akan system. The first view, put forward by Arkoh and Matthewson (2013), is that *no* is a “familiarity definite” in the sense of Schwarz (2009), cf. (7). In this analysis, *no* is modeled after the German strong article, and includes a pronominal index in its denotation. This index imposes the requirement that the referent be a familiar antecedent.

- (7) *Familiarity analysis of ‘no’*
 a. $\llbracket no \rrbracket = \lambda s. \lambda P. \lambda y. \iota x [P(x)(s) \wedge x = y]$
 b. $\llbracket atadeɛ no_1 \rrbracket^g = \iota x [dress(x)(s_r) \wedge x = g(1)]$,
 defined iff there is a (weakly) familiar dress in s_r identical to $g(1)$

Owusu (2022, 2025) enriches this denotation with an anti-uniqueness presupposition – that is, a requirement that the referent be non-unique in an extended or global situation. This captures the (alleged) incompatibility of *no* with global singletons like *sun*: anti-uniqueness requires there to be more than one sun, a condition which is not satisfied in the actual world.

The main challenge of these approaches is that indexed definites like (7) usually require an overt antecedent, whereas *no* is possible without prior mention, as in (3). To account for this, Arkoh and Matthewson and Owusu relax the antecedent presupposition to a “weak familiarity” condition, which merely requires the referent to be hearer-old (i.e. ‘known’ to the interlocutors), rather than pre-mentioned. This contrasts with the strong article in German, which is strictly anaphoric.

Despite this shortcoming, familiarity approaches have an appealing narrative for the bare noun. Capitalising on (5), they identify it as the uniqueness definite of the language. Based on this setup, Arkoh and Matthewson (2013) argue that Akan supports the view that “there are two types of definites cross-linguistically” (Schwarz, 2013).² In turn, in Owusu (2022) the bare noun is the only possible option with global singletons, on account of the anti-uniqueness presupposition of *no*.

The second view on the Akan system is that *no* is a uniqueness article – in essence, a Frege/Strawson definite presupposing uniqueness (Bombi, 2018; Bombi et al., 2019).

²For problems of this portrayal, see Bombi (2018) and Coppock (2022).

(8) *Uniqueness analysis of ‘no’*

- a. $\llbracket no \rrbracket = \lambda s. \lambda P : \exists! x [P(x)(s)]. \iota x [P(x)(s)]$
- b. $\llbracket atade \epsilon no_s \rrbracket = \iota x [dress(x)(s)]$ defined iff there is exactly one dress in s

The analysis was supported by fieldwork data showing that *no* does in fact occur in larger and global uniqueness, cf. (6). In turn, anaphoric uses of the determiner were treated as special cases of uniqueness (see Beaver and Coppock, 2015 for a formalisation deriving ‘familiarity’ from uniqueness).

However, this approach left aspects of the definite bare noun unexplained. There are at least two challenges. First, it is unclear why the form should be available in the first place. Based on Chierchia (1998), bare nominals may only undergo a (ι -) type shift if there is no corresponding overt determiner in the language. If, as proposed by uniqueness theories, *no* lexicalises ι , the definite bare noun should be blocked. Second, if the type-shift is indeed possible, it is unclear why it cannot apply in anaphora, where *no* is obligatory and the bare noun is banned – assuming, as the theory does, that anaphora may be subsumed under uniqueness.

A possible solution to these challenges is to treat the bare noun not as a simple definite, but as a special proper name – an idea that has been suggested in the previous literature. Bombi et al. (2019: 190) observed that only certain Akan nouns (titles and celestial objects) can be definite and bare, which lead them to propose that these nouns are best analysed as proper names. This proposal is supported by recent cross-linguistic evidence: as noted by Yip et al. (2023), Cantonese and Bangla have a broader set of so-called quasi-names than English, which include notions like professions, titles, and globally unique entities. As argued by Coppock and Bonney (2024), a similar situation may also obtain in Akan. However, a more in-depth investigation of this phenomenon is lacking – a gap this paper aims to address.

3. Data: Akan bare nouns as quasi-names

Based on newly collected data, we argue that at least some definite bare nouns in Akan are quasi-names. Following Yip et al. (2023), we show how they display two typical properties of this category: a special relation to the speaker and the addressee (Section 3.1), and lexical restrictions (Section 3.2). Unlike earlier descriptions, however, they seem to allow for narrow-scope readings (Section 3.3). Our discussion focuses on human nouns, but we briefly discuss non-human nouns in Section 5.3.

The data come from elicitations with 15 speakers of Akan (Asante Twi variety), which took place in Accra, Berlin and online between 2024 and 2026.³ In particular, Sections 3.1, 3.2, and 5.3 are based on a questionnaire whose goal was to establish, first, whether all nouns can be definite and bare, and second, whether uniqueness is sufficient to license the (definite) bare noun. To this end, we picked 33 nouns whose intended referent was typically unique in some context, e.g. a blackboard in a class, a president in a country, a coffin at a funeral, etc. We tested sentences

³All of our speakers were native speakers of Asante Twi. Our selection criteria were that the speaker grew up in a Twi speaking community, with at least one parent speaking Asante Twi. We have observed a tendency for speakers with a more homogeneous linguistic background (both parents are Twi, Twi and English as the only languages, grew up in Asante region) to provide native Twi words more consistently. Speaker background is a potential factor to be controlled more thoroughly in future work.

containing these nouns across two contexts: one supporting uniqueness, and one establishing, additionally, that the interlocutors have a special relation to the referent (as required by quasi-names, cf. Section 3.1). The task was a translation task in context, immediately followed by a felicity judgement task, which allowed speakers to volunteer their preferred target noun, rather than being restricted to the variant presented by the interviewer.

In terms of predictions, the quasi-name analysis predicted definite bare nouns to only be licensed under particular conditions, namely only with some nouns and in the quasi-name-supporting context. Conversely, the uniqueness theory predicted a wider distribution, with all nouns being possible across both contexts. As we argue in what follows, the data align with the quasi-name hypothesis.

3.1. Quasi-name property I: Relation to speaker and addressee

As described in Yip et al. (2023), quasi-names encode a relation to the speaker and the addressee. To illustrate with English, the quasi-name *Dad* in (9) usually refers to the interlocutors' father, unlike the corresponding definite description.

- (9) Whenever I go to a family party, *Dad* / *the dad* bakes a cake.

Definite bare nouns in Akan show a similar behaviour. In (10a), the referent is the director of the interlocutors' company. Here, the bare noun is licensed (and *no* is infelicitous). By contrast, when the referent is not the interlocutors' director, *no* is required, cf. (10b).

- (10) a. (+RELATION: Akrobeto and Brefa work at the same company. One day, Brefa doesn't show. The next day, Akrobeto wants to find out why. She says:)
 Na {**directa** / # **directa no**} pɛ sɛ me-yɛ adwuma firi fie.
 PST director director DEF want COMP 1SG-do work from home
 'The director wanted me to work from home.' (0: 5/5, *no*: 1/5)
- b. (−RELATION: Akrobeto and Brefa live in the same house, but work at different companies. One day, Brefa doesn't got to work. Akrobeto asks why. She says:)
 Na {# **directa** / **directa no**} pɛ sɛ me-yɛ adwuma firi fie.
 PST director director DEF want COMP 1SG-do work from home
 'The director wanted me to work from home.' (0: 2/5, *no*: 5/5)⁴

Similarly, in (11), the bare noun is only licensed when the interlocutors regularly buy from the fish-seller in question.

- (11) a. (+RELATION: Maame Ama and Akosua have a woman who regularly supplies them with fish every evening. It's always the same one. Today, she comes in the morning. Akosua tells Maame Ama:)
 {ɛ**namwura** / ɛ**namwura no**} ba-a ntɛm.
 fish-seller fish-seller DEF come-PST early
 'The fish-seller came early.' (0: 2/3, *no*: 3/3)

⁴Speakers who accepted the bare noun in the −Relation context commented that it was possible only if Akrobeto talked about the director at home (potentially establishing a +Relation context). We expect lower acceptability if none of the two speakers has some relation to the director. Thanks to Ka Fai Yip for discussion of this point.

Comment: ‘no’ is optional but usually the bare noun is used because they both know the fish-seller.

- b. (–RELATION: Maame Ama is visiting a friend in a different town. It is 5am and food is ready. Maame Ama is surprised and asks why. Her friend says:)

{εnamwura no / #εnamwura} ba-a ntɛm.
fish-seller DEF fish-seller come-PST early

‘The fish-seller came early.’

(0: 0/3, no: 3/3)

Comment: *The friend does not know the fish-seller, so it would be odd to use the bare noun.*

Additional evidence that the relation factor is relevant in the alternation comes from spontaneous speakers’ comments:

- (12) a. (+RELATION context: Two teachers talking about the headmaster of their school):
They are colleagues, they know the headmaster. It wouldn’t really flow [with ‘no’].
b. (–RELATION context: Two Ghanaians referring to the president of Nigeria):
Usually, when it’s someone you are familiar with, then you can omit the ‘no’. But here it’s a foreign person.

3.2. Property II: Lexical restrictions

Only some nouns can be quasi-names, and these are lexically determined. This means that only some nouns occur bare with a definite interpretation, provided that the relation to the interlocutors holds. It also means that a complementary set of nouns cannot be bare and definite, even if the context establishes the relevant relation.

The nouns we have considered so far (‘director’, ‘fish-seller’) belong to the first category of quasi-name-allowing nouns. By contrast, *mate* ‘fare collector’ (unique on a bus) and *ɔka(sa)mafoɔ* ‘speaker’ (unique at a lecture) are not quasi-names. With these nouns, the article *no* is required to achieve a definite interpretation, even in +Relation contexts, cf. (13)–(14).

- (13) (+RELATION: Kofi and Kwame always take the same trotro [public transportation van] to work. Since it’s a small town, it’s always the same driver and mate – and Kofi and Kwame know them pretty well. Kwame is not in town, and Kofi is telling him how things went last Wednesday. He says: “I took our trotro...”)⁵

Me-foro-yɛ no, {mate no / #mate} kyea-a me.

1SG-enter-PST DEF mate DEF mate greet-PST 1SG.ACC

‘When I entered, the mate greeted me.’

(0: 0/4, no: 4/4)

- (14) (+RELATION: Akua is part of a lecture group that meets every Friday. Everybody knows each other pretty well. They always have the same speaker. One day, things are unexpectedly slow, so one organiser says:)

⁵These examples arguably involve bridging. Bombi (2018) argues that bridging does not distinguish between two types of definites in Akan but always involves uniqueness.

Quasi-names in Akan

{ɔkasamafoɔ no / # ɔkasamafoɔ} bɛ-ba seisei ara.
 speaker DEF speaker FUT-come now INT
 ‘The speaker will arrive soon.’ (Ø: 0/3, no: 3/3)⁶

A preliminary list of quasi-name-allowing nouns can be found in (15). For contrast, (16) shows a list of nouns that are not quasi-names, alongside the contexts in which they are unique. We focus on human nouns only.

- (15) QUASI-NAMES
maa / mama / maame ‘mum, mother’, *paapa / papa / daa / *agya* ‘dad, father’, *nana* ‘chief, king’, *ɔmanpanyin* ‘president’, *headmaster* ‘headmaster’, *tikya* ‘teacher’, *bosu / adwumawura* ‘boss’, *directa* ‘director’, (ɛ)*namwura* ‘fish-seller’, (ɔ)*sɔfo* ‘pastor’, *efie-wura* ‘landlord’, *dɔkota* ‘doctor’, **Asantehene* ‘king of the Ashantis’, **ɔkyeame* ‘royal spokesperson’⁷
- (16) NOT QUASI-NAMES
mate ‘fare-collector’ (bus/trotro), *driva / drɔbani / ɔhyɛnkanin* ‘driver’ (bus), *ɔkyerekyerɛni* ‘teacher’ (class), *abofra / akwadaa* ‘child’ (naming ceremony), *ɔnwontonin* ‘singer’ (band), *mmrahyɛbadwanin* ‘parliamentarian’ (constituency), *speaka(ni) / ɔkasamafoɔ / ɔkamafoɔ* ‘speaker’ (lecture)

It seems that near-synonyms may belong to different categories, which lends support to the idea that quasi-names are lexically determined. For example, ‘teacher’ has a loanword variant (*tikya*) and a native variant (*ɔkyerekyerɛni*). In +Relation contexts, the bare noun was often rejected with the native word, but accepted (and suggested by speakers) with the loanword, cf. (17). This suggests that only *tikya* can be a quasi-name. We impressionistically observed similar lexicalisation patterns for other loanword/native pairs.

- (17) (+RELATION: Akua and her sister Martha are in the same class. They are in primary school, so they only have one teacher. One day Martha is sick, and her sister is telling her what happened in class: “It was nice today...”)
- {ɔkyerekyerɛni # (no) / tikya (ɔ% no)} ka-a ani-ka nnoɔma kyere yɛn.
 teacher DEF teacher DEF say-PST eye-itch things show 2PL
 ‘The teacher told us many interesting things.’ (*tikya* Ø: 3/3, *ɔkyerekyerɛni* Ø: 1/4)

3.3. Property III: Wide and narrow scope?

Yip et al. (2023) identify rigidity as a typical property of quasi-names. This is based on the observation that, in Cantonese and Bangla, they take wide scope over intensional operators. We did not exhaustively apply Yip et al.’s tests to Akan, but found preliminary evidence that bare nouns in this language are able to take narrow scope. Rather than challenging their status as quasi-names, we argue that their scopal properties may vary cross-linguistically.

⁶The contrast reported here is based on three judgments given for three variants of ‘speaker’, namely *speaker*, *ɔkasamafoɔ* and *ɔkamafoɔ*.

⁷Nouns marked with ‘*’ were not tested systematically but were suggested in speakers’ comments.

At first sight, Akan quasi-names seem to take only wide scope, similar to Cantonese and Bangla. For instance, in (18), the bare noun *sɔfo* ‘pastor’ was only accepted when it referred to a specific person (Reverend Daniel) but not when it referred to the unique pastor in the church situations quantified over in (18b).

- (18) a. (NO COVARIATION: Kwaku and Papa Yaw both attend the same church, and they are very close to the lead pastor, Reverend Daniel Asare. Although he travels a lot, Kwaku always manages to go to his church every Sunday to receive a blessing. He tells Papa Yaw about this:)
- ɛberɛ biara aa mɛ-kɔ asɔrɛ no, sɔfo / sɔfo no hyira me.
time every REL 1SG-go church DEF.CL pastor pastor DEF bless me
‘Every time I go to church, the pastor blesses me.’ (0: 3/3, no: 2/3)
Comment: *I didn’t include the no because it’s already established it’s Rev. Daniel.*
- b. (COVARIATION: Kwaku travels a lot for work, and each week he gets sent to a different town. Every Sunday, he goes to the local church there. Kwaku is telling someone about this.)
- ɛberɛ biara aa mɛ-kɔ asɔrɛ no, #sɔfo / sɔfo no hyira me.
time every REL 1SG-go church DEF.CL pastor pastor DEF bless me
‘Every time I go to church, the pastor blesses me.’ (0: 0/3, no: 2/3)

However, there is a confound. As we saw in Section 3.1, quasi-names can only be used in +Relation contexts. The situations quantified over in (18b) do not support this relation: Kwaku and his interlocutor do not know the pastors of the churches he visited. Thus, it is not possible to establish whether the infelicity of the quasi-name is due to an inability to take narrow scope, or because the relation condition is not satisfied.

When this factor is controlled for, quasi-names seem to allow for narrow scope readings. In (19), the relation condition is satisfied (the speakers are talking about “their” president), and the noun phrase does not refer to a specific individual, but to whoever happens to be the president of Ghana at the time. Here, the quasi-name was accepted. Another example of variable reference across time can be found in (20).

- (19) (COVARIATION WITH TIME ADVERBIALS: Kwasi is from Ghana, but he works in Nigeria. He always makes sure to see his family every four or five years. When he does, he goes to Accra for the National Day Celebrations – which are attended by whoever the president and ministers are at that time. Kwasi says:)
- ɛberɛ biara aa mɛ-kɔ Ghana no, me-hunu ɔmanpanyin no / ɔmanpanyin.
time every REL 1SG-go Ghana DEF.CL 1SG-see president DEF president
‘Every time I go to Ghana I see the president.’ (2/2)
- (20) (Two people talk about how times are changing in Ghana. Women’s most important task used to be childcare but now they can go to the office. Even the government may be affected.)
- Mprɛnprɛn yi no, ɔmanpanyin (no) yɛ ɔbarima. Da bi, ɔmanpanyin (no)
time PROX DEF.CL president DEF COP man day INDF president DEF

Quasi-names in Akan

bɛ-yɛ ɔbaa.

FUT-COP woman

‘Currently, the president is a man. One day, the president will be a woman.’ (2/3)

Comment: [with the BN] *It can be two different people.*

These examples, to be confirmed in future research, suggest that Akan quasi-names are not rigid. Apparent obligatory wide-scope seems to be a by-product of the relation condition, which is often not satisfied in covariation examples.

Note that lack of rigidity does not speak against a quasi-name analysis. Consider the English quasi-name *matron* in (21), taken from a petition to the UK Parliament:⁸

(21) Bring back **matron** to every hospital ward.

The campaigners’ request was that there should be a (unique) matron for each hospital ward, not that a specific matron should be present in all wards. Thus, we find that at least not all quasi-names cross-linguistically are rigid – including Akan quasi-names.

4. Towards an analysis

4.1. Basic patterns

For the analysis of Akan quasi-names, we broadly adopt Yip et al.’s (2023) formalisation, but modify it to capture narrow scope readings. The analysis involves two basic components: the NP denotation (involving a name-bearing property), and a special null D (a propriial article, i.e. an article for proper names).

Regarding the first, the assumption is that nouns such as *directa* ‘director’ or *ɔmanpanyin* ‘president’ are ambiguous between two options: common noun properties, (22a); and (quasi-)name-bearing properties, (22b). In its common noun variant, *ɔmanpanyin* denotes the set of entities that are presidents. In its quasi-name variant, it denotes the set of entities that bear the name *ɔmanpanyin*, and presupposes that those entities are indeed presidents.

- (22) a. $\llbracket \text{ɔmanpanyin}_{CN} \rrbracket = \lambda x. \text{president}(x)$
 b. $\llbracket \text{ɔmanpanyin}_{QN} \rrbracket = \lambda x. x \text{ bears the name ‘ɔmanpanyin’, defined iff } \text{president}(x)$

The second component of the analysis concerns the determiner. While ‘regular’ common nouns combine with the definite *no* (analysed here as a uniqueness definite, (23a)), quasi-name-bearing properties combine with the null D_{QN} in (23b).

- (23) *Denotations of ‘no’ and D_{QN}*
 a. $\llbracket no \rrbracket = \lambda s. \lambda P. \lambda x. [P(x)(s)]$
 b. $\llbracket D_{QN} \rrbracket^c = \lambda s. \lambda P_n. \lambda x. [P_n(x)(s) \wedge \text{Rel}_{QN}(x, sp \oplus ad)(s)]$
 defined iff $\exists !x [P_n(x)(s) \wedge \text{Rel}_{QN}(x, sp \oplus ad)(s)]$

⁸<https://www.change.org/p/teresa-may-bring-back-matron-to-all-hospital-wards>, accessed on February 8th 2026. We thank Peter Sutton for bringing this example to our attention.

D_{QN} is a proprial article, i.e. a definite article that only combines with names (Muñoz, 2019), which takes a name-bearing property (P_n) and returns an individual. The restrictor includes a functional relation to the speaker and the addressee, which we label the ‘quasi-name relation’ (Rel_{QN}). In essence, this relation is a function mapping the speaker and the addressee to the unique headmaster, president, boss, etc. of the speaker and the addressee’s community. This is illustrated schematically in (24) (after Yip et al., 2023: 258).

- (24) *Quasi-name relation Rel_{QN}*
- a. speaker/addressee $\longrightarrow$ x: x is the *headmaster* of the sp+ad’s community
 - b. speaker/addressee $\longrightarrow$ x: x is the *president* of the sp+ad’s community
 - c. speaker/addressee $\longrightarrow$ x: x is the *boss* of the sp+ad’s community

In their account of Bangla and Cantonese quasi-names, Yip et al. (2023) also assume an index taken by a world-insensitive assignment function, to ensure the rigidity. Since Akan quasi-names are not rigid, we omit this component.

This denotation captures the properties of quasi-names as follows. The Rel_{QN} component is responsible for the relation requirement, introducing the presupposition that the referent be related in the relevant sense to the interlocutors. To illustrate, the quasi-name *directa* has the denotation in (25a). The presupposition was satisfied in the director example in (10a), since the referent was the director of the company where both interlocutors work, licensing the quasi-name. By contrast, in (10b) the relation component was not met, since the referent was not the addressee’s director. However, uniqueness was satisfied, since companies usually have one director. Thus, the definite description in (25b), but not the quasi-name, was licensed.

- (25) a. $[[directa \emptyset]]^{g,c}$
 $= \iota x [x \text{ bears the name ‘directa’ in } s \wedge Rel_{QN}(x, sp \oplus ad)(s)],$
defined iff there is exactly one x named ‘directa’ in s that is the director
of the sp+add’s community in s
- b. $[[directa no]]^g$
 $= \iota x [director(x)(s)],$ defined iff there is exactly one director in s

We also attribute the wide scope readings of (18) (pastor example) to the Rel_{QN} component. The example is repeated in ‘pseudo-English’ in (26a). Assuming our denotation of quasi-names, a covarying interpretation can be paraphrased as in (26b). In order for this reading to be available in (18), the pastors in the situations quantified over should have been part of the the interlocutors’ community. Since this was not specified in the context, the reading was not available.

- (26) *No covariation due to Rel_{QN} , cf. (18)*
- a. Every time I go to church, **pastor** blesses me.
 - b. #For every situation s’ in x, where x is a church: the unique y named ‘sofo’ in s’ such that y is the unique pastor of the interlocutors’ community in s’ blesses the speaker.

By contrast, covariation was admissible across time in (19), paraphrased in (27a), which has the intended reading in (27b).

(27) *Covariation with quasi-name, cf. (19)*

- a. Every time I go to Ghana, I see **president**.
- b. In every s' , t : s' is a situation in Ghana at time t , the speaker sees the unique entity named 'ɔmanpanyin' in s' that is the unique president of the interlocutors' community in s' .

In this example, the presuppositional component of Rel_{QN} is satisfied, since we are always dealing with the president of Ghana, i.e. the president of the community of the interlocutors. However, the quasi-name does not refer to a particular individual, but to whoever fulfils that role in that particular situation. Thus, the quasi-name is licensed with the intended covarying interpretation.

4.2. Quasi-name subtypes

With the basic analysis in place, we can now distinguish two quasi-name subtypes. First, there are nouns that only surface as quasi-names, i.e. that only occur bare and in +Relation contexts. *Mààmé* 'mother', *pàápá* 'father' and *nana* 'chief' belong to this category.⁹ In –Relation contexts a different form (*mààmé* 'mother', *pàpá* 'father', *ohene* 'chief, king') is used, cf. (28).

- (28) a. (+RELATION: Kwame and Martha are from the same village. Kwame visited the village for the National Ghana Day celebrations, but Martha couldn't attend. Kwame is telling her what happened. He says: "When we arrived...")

Nana / %**ohene** kyea-a yɛn.

chief_{QN} chief_{CN} greet-PST 2PL

'The chief greeted us.'

(*nana*: 3/3, *ohene*: 2/4)¹⁰

Comment: *When we know the chief, we prefer 'nana' (cannot be used with 'no').*

- b. (–RELATION: Kwame is from the Ashanti region and is traveling to Cote d'Ivoire for the first time. He is documenting the traditional way of life in a village there. He is telling his Ashanti friend what happened. He says: "When we arrived...")

#**Nana no** / **ohene no** kyea-a yɛn.

chief_{QN} DEF chief_{CN} DEF greet-PST 2PL

'The chief greeted us.'

(*nana no*: 0/2, *ohene no*: 2/2)

Comment: *I cannot use 'nana' here because the chief is from another place. Ohene is appropriate.*

The analysis for this pattern is that some nouns are lexically determined to only be quasi-names. Put differently, the quasi-name and the common noun entries correspond to two phonological forms, (29).

(29) *Lexical entries for 'chief'*

- a. $[[ohene_{CN}]] = \lambda x. \text{chief}(x)$
- b. $[[nana_{QN}]] = \lambda x. x \text{ bears the name 'nana', defined iff } \text{chief}(x)$

⁹*Nana* can be used as a regular common noun, but it means elder/grandfather, rather than chief.

¹⁰*Ohene* can also be a given name and speakers' comments suggest that they may have accepted the bare noun in this sense, not as a quasi-name. In contrast to *nana*, in –Relation contexts, the responses for *ohene* were rather unclear. We report the judgements of speakers that provided had a clearer intuition.

In the second pattern, the same noun has a quasi-name and a common noun entry, (30). Nouns belonging to this category include *ɔmanpanyin* ‘president’, *tikya* ‘teacher’, and *directa* ‘director’. The common noun entry combines with *no* (yielding a regular definite description), and the quasi-name entry combines with D_{QN} (yielding a quasi-name).

- (30) a. $\llbracket tikya_{CN} \rrbracket = \lambda x. \text{teacher}(x)$
 b. $\llbracket tikya_{QN} \rrbracket = \lambda x. x \text{ bears the name 'tikya', defined iff } \text{teacher}(x)$

For the most part, however, nouns in Akan are not quasi-names, and they denote regular properties. All nouns listed as ‘not quasi-name-allowing’ in (16) belong to this category. Thus, *ɔkyerɛkyerɛni*, the native variant of teacher, only has the common noun entry in (31), and needs to be combined with *no* to receive a definite interpretation.

- (31) $\llbracket \text{ɔkyerɛkyerɛni}_{CN} \rrbracket = \lambda x. \text{teacher}(x)$

5. Discussion: Expanding the theory of quasi-names

Having laid out the foundations, this section elaborates on different aspects of the quasi-name theory, linking it to open questions in the literature. First, we explain how quasi-names and *no* compete in uniqueness contexts (Section 5.1). Second, we formulate a hypothesis as to which nouns become quasi-names (Section 5.2). Then, we discuss non-human quasi-names (Section 5.3). Finally, we relate quasi-names to other phenomena cross-linguistically (Section 5.4).

5.1. Competition with the definite

In the previous literature, there were several open questions regarding the competition between *no* and the bare noun. The quasi-name analyses addresses at least two of them. To begin with, there was the issue of blocking: the uniqueness analysis of *no* tacitly assumed that the bare noun involved an ι type shift. This was a problem, since, based on Chierchia (1998), this should have been blocked by *no*. The quasi-name analysis surmounts this problem: the bare noun involves a silent D, not a type shift; most importantly, it does not involve a simple ι but a more complex meaning, which would prevent blocking regardless.

The second issue was empirical: the exact distribution of bare nouns in (larger) uniqueness was unclear. We already provided a short account of their distribution: at least with human nouns, bare nouns (which are quasi-names) can only appear if the context supplies the relation to the interlocutors, and if the noun is lexicalised as a quasi-name.

A more precise breakdown of these factors can be found in (32). The table is to be read as follows. First, the distribution depends on whether a quasi-name bearing property is available (rows 1a/1b) or not (row 2). If it is available, the relevant noun may surface only as a quasi-name, as discussed in the previous section (row 1a), or both as a quasi-name and as a regular common noun (row 1b). Further, whether the quasi-name is licensed depends on whether the context satisfies the Rel_{QN} condition, i.e. whether we are dealing with a +Relation or a –Relation context.

Quasi-names in Akan

(32) *Distribution of ‘no’ vs. quasi-names*

		$\emptyset$		<i>no</i>		Example
		+ <i>Rel</i> _{QN}	– <i>Rel</i> _{QN}	+ <i>Rel</i> _{QN}	– <i>Rel</i> _{QN}	
1a	Only QN	✓	✗	✗	✗	<i>nana</i> ‘chief’
1b	QN + CN	✓	✗	✗/✓	✓	<i>ɔmanpanyin</i> ‘president’
2	Not QN	✗	✗	✓	✓	<i>mate</i> ‘fare collector’

An aspect to be clarified is the distribution in +Relation contexts, and whether quasi-names are obligatory in these contexts. Put simply, if the interlocutors are talking about “their” boss or “their” president, must they use the quasi-name, or is *no* also possible?

Overall, nouns varied in whether the quasi-name was required, and the preferences also varied across speakers. This is indicated as ‘✓/✗’ in (32). On the one hand, the definite was considered optional with *ɛnamwura* ‘fish-seller’ in (11). Similarly, *ɔmanpanyin* ‘president’ was preferred bare in our main questionnaire, but *no* was the first option volunteered in (19) (covariation examples). On the other hand, the quasi-name was mostly seen as obligatory for *boss/bosu* ‘boss’, *tikya* ‘teacher’, and *directa* ‘director’.

We also observed anti-honorific effects with the definite *no* (cf. Sharma and Chen 2026 for a similar pattern in Magahi, Indo-Aryan). Speakers that perceived that a particular quasi-name was obligatory in a +Relation context, also commented that using *no* instead leads to a derogatory reading, cf. (33).¹¹

- (33) a. (*ɛfiewura* ‘landlord’, +RELATION context:)
If they both know [the landlord] ... If you use the no, you have an issue with the landord. It means you don’t like the person.
- b. (*sɔfo* ‘pastor’, +RELATION context:)
[with no] it would be informal... You are underrating somebody’s position. As if he’s not relevant. It will sound disrespectful.

The non-obligatoriness of quasi-names challenges standard assumptions about presuppositional competition. The contexts supporting the presupposition of the quasi-name (which requires both uniqueness and relation) are a proper subset of those that, in principle, satisfy the uniqueness presupposition of *no*. If Maximize Presupposition (MP) is operating in Akan, we expect *D*_{QN} to win over *no*, in case uniqueness and relation are satisfied – contrary to fact. A potential way out of this problem would be to treat the conditions on quasi-names not as presuppositions (as we have done here), but as expressive content – turning the competition between the two forms into matter of register, formality or closeness levels (cf. McCready, 2019 for role honorifics). The exploration of this idea is left to future research.

¹¹The derogatory potential of *no* is noted by Arkoh and Matthewson (2013: 19, fn. 21), see also Coppock and Bonney (2024: 15).

5.2. Which nouns do (not) become quasi-names? Some hypotheses

While quasi-names are lexically determined, we have observed semantic regularities. Indeed, there is considerable overlap between Akan quasi-names and Bangla/Cantonese ones (Yip et al., 2023). This raises the question of which factors determine the lexicalisation of quasi-names cross-linguistically.

Yip et al. (2023) suggest that the choice of quasi-names is limited to entities whose uniqueness is established in a conventionalised context – but this characterisation is insufficient. On a theoretical level, “conventionalised uniqueness” corresponds to larger uniqueness, which, as we have seen, displays a mixed pattern when it comes to quasi-names. For instance, ‘mates’ (fare collectors) are generally unique in a ‘trotro’ (local public transport), but the noun is not a quasi-name.

We propose that, for lexicalisation to occur, at least one further factor needs to be conventionalised (and durable) – namely the relation component. Many nouns that are not quasi-name-allowing are conventionally unique, but fail this second condition. To go back to our previous examples, a ‘mate’ is unique in a trotro, but it generally changes with every bus trip: there is no consistent relation between a particular individual and the interlocutors. Another example is a child at a naming ceremony, where the newborn is given its name, eight days after birth. Here, uniqueness is circumscribed to this particular event, and the relevant ‘community of the interlocutors’ is also temporary. This issue was also reflected in the data collection process: for these nouns, it was difficult to create a +Relation context for testing.

An intriguing correlation can also be observed between quasi-names and titles. Native Akan words that are quasi-names often involve high-status roles, such as *nana* ‘chief’, *ɔkyeame* ‘royal spokesperson’, and *Asantehene* ‘king of the Ashantis’. This suggests that ‘title-hood’ also facilitates the lexicalisation as a quasi-name. More research is required to establish whether this is the case.

5.3. Non-human quasi-names

Our previous discussion focussed on quasi-names denoting humans. However, we know from the previous literature that non-human nouns like *awia* ‘sun’ can also be bare and definite. We argue that these nouns are also quasi-names, although they conform less neatly to the pattern outlined above.

The main argument to treat them as quasi-names is that there are lexical restrictions. Indeed, celestial objects (*awia* ‘sun’, *bosome* ‘moon’) and institutions (*sukuu* ‘school’) were accepted as definite bare nouns, cf. (34). Other unique nouns (*funuadaka* ‘coffin’, *fridge* ‘fridge’, *adwumakuo* ‘company’) were not, cf. (35).

(34) Non-human quasi-names

- a. (Two friends want to go out for a walk, but it’s already getting dark. One of them complains about it. The other says: “Don’t worry...”)

{ **Awia / Awia no** } be-pue ɔkyena nso.

sun sun DEF FUT-appear tomorrow ADD

‘The sun will come out again tomorrow.’

(∅: 3/5, no: 5/5)¹²

¹²One speaker who rejected the bare noun here accepted it in a similar episodic context.

Quasi-names in Akan

- b. (A mother is making enquires at her child's school. She wants to know how long the holidays will last. The secretary says:)

{**Sukuu** / % **Sukuu no**} be-bue ɛbɔ bosome no mu.
 school school DEF FUT-open September month DEF in
 'School will reopen in September.'
 (0: 5/5, no: 3/5)

(35) *Non-human nouns (not quasi-names)*

- a. (A family is going back home from a holiday. The mother packs leftover food into the car. She says to the father: "We need to make preparations...")

Yɛ-bɛ-duru no, na {# **fridge** / **fridge no**} adum.
 1PL-FUT-arrive DEF.CL NA fridge fridge DEF off
 'The fridge will be off when we arrive there.'
 (0: 0/2, no: 2/2)

- b. (At the end of the year, the boss of a company gives a speech to his employees:)

{# **Adwumakuo** / **Adwumakuo no**} bɛ-fa adwuma-foɔ foroɔ afe yi.
 company company DEF FUT-take worker-PL new year this
 'The company will take new workers this year.'
 (0: 0/2, no: 2/2)

However, with regard to other quasi-name properties, the situation is less homogeneous than for humans. First, for 'sun' and 'moon', it was difficult to find a relevant +/-Relation contrast. In general, speakers volunteered the option with *no* but also accepted the bare noun. Second, nouns like 'school' are polysemous between at least three senses: a building, the general institution of schooling, and a particular institution (e.g. 'Legon Presec School'). It is unclear for which of the senses the bare noun was accepted in (34b), which made it difficult to establish whether the relation component of quasi-names was at work. For yet other nouns ('main gate', 'post office'), it was not clear whether we were dealing with quasi-names or with genuine proper names.

To sum up, non-human quasi-names also seem to exist, based on the lexical restrictions described above. However, the role of Rel_{QN} and a broader list of non-human quasi-names remains to be established.

5.4. Relation to other phenomena cross-linguistically

Akan quasi-names are reminiscent of other phenomena in which nouns connected to institutional roles exhibit peculiar behaviour. We briefly discuss three such cases (imposters, role honorifics, complex names as indices) and explore how they relate to quasi-names.

First, names and titles are within the class of English nouns that can be used as imposters – grammatically 3rd person DPs that are notionally 1st or 2nd person (from Collins and Postal, 2012: 3):

- (36) a. Is **Madam** not feeling well?
 b. Is **the general** going to dine in his suite?

It appears that at least some quasi-names in Akan can be used as 2nd person imposters:

- (37) (A newly appointed teacher is very helpful. She notices the headmaster working long hours. She approaches him and says:)

ase **maseta** (# no) wa-yε busy.
seems (head)master DEF 2SG.PST-COP busy
'The headmaster seems busy.'
(Ø: 2/3, no: 0/3)

- (38) (After hearing of an upcoming promotion, Kwame is being very nice to his boss. During a break, he goes to the boss's office and says to him:)
Dabiara na **boss** re-yε adwuma. Metumi aboa anaa?
always NA boss PROG-do work 1SG.can help POL.Q
'The boss is always working. Can I help?'
(Ø: 3/4)

Speakers clarified that, while the bare noun usually refers to someone who is not participating in the conversation, they may also appear appear in the above contexts with a 'jovial tone' or when the speaker has a personal relation to the interlocutor. The comment fits well with prior descriptions of imposters, which are often tied to particular registers.

Second, the behaviour and inventory of quasi-names closely resembles that of role honorifics in Thai – i.e. noun phrases that indicate honorification "as a side-effect of their core meaning", by highlighting the profession of the addressee (McCready, 2019: 82). Thai role honorifics can be used in argument position with a definite interpretation, as in (39).

- (39) **aacaan** bpai bpraasăi.
teacher go presentation
'The teacher is going to the talk.'
(Thai, McCready, 2019: 83)

This shows, first, that Thai role honorifics may also be quasi-names. Conversely, we can also hypothesise that Akan quasi-names involve some degree of honorification – a connection to be explored in further research.

Finally, however, Akan quasi-names cannot be treated as complex indices, unlike their Thai correlates. The notion of 'complex index' refers to the syntactic behavior of Thai proper names and honorifics, which appear to violate Condition C of the Binding Theory, cf. (40). To capture these data, Chaiphet and Jenks (2021) propose that they are indexical expressions similar to pronouns, but with a more complex admissibility condition.

- (40) **aacaan**₁ sŏnsăj wâa **aacaan**₁ pùaj.
teacher.HON wonder COMP teacher.HON ill
'The teacher wonders if s/he's ill.'
(Thai, Chaiphet and Jenks, 2021: 3)

Although they resemble Thai honorifics in other ways, Akan (quasi-)names are subject to Condition C, cf. (41), and thus cannot be subsumed under Chaiphet and Jenks's analysis.

- (41) a. **Yaw**₁ se {***Yaw**₁ yare / ɔ₁-yare}.
Yaw COMP Yaw be.sick 3SG-be.sick
'Yaw says that he is sick.'
(Yaw: 0/3, ɔ-: 3/3)
b. (Yaw wants to talk to his boss. A co-worker says:)
Boss₁ se {***boss**₁ m-ba / ɔ₁-m-ba} adwuma ɔkyena.
boss say boss NEG-come 3SG-NEG-come work tomorrow
'The boss said that he wouldn't come to work tomorrow.'
(Boss: 0/3, ɔ-: 2/2)

As these examples show, quasi-names go beyond the Akan definiteness debate, and their study may inform (or be informed by) phenomena in other languages.

6. Conclusion

In this paper, we have argued that (some) definite bare nouns in Akan are quasi-names. The main evidence was, first, the obligatory relation with the speaker and the addressee and, second, the fact that not all nouns can be bare and definite. These special licensing conditions are in line with Yip et al.'s (2023) descriptions of quasi-names, and are unexpected if the bare noun in Akan is a run-of-the-mill uniqueness definite, as proposed by Arkoh and Matthewson (2013).

The quasi-name analysis directly addresses unresolved issues in the literature. One empirical point was whether *no* and the bare noun are both possible in larger uniqueness, and to what extent. The answer to this question is that the bare noun, at least for humans, is only licensed if it is lexicalised as a quasi-name and if the context satisfies its more complex presupposition. Thus, contrary to what was argued in Bombi (2018), the definite and the bare noun are not in free variation. For non-human quasi-names, the factors behind the alternation remain unclear – yet the data confirmed that *awia no* ‘the sun’ is equally acceptable as *awia* ‘sun’ in episodic contexts (contra Owusu, 2022).

More broadly, the analysis can be seen as providing a missing piece of the uniqueness theory of *no* (Bombi, 2018; Bombi et al., 2019).¹³ Indeed, it provides a more precise characterisation of the nature and distribution of the bare noun in Akan, which was left unaddressed. The proposal can also be seen as an alternative to Owusu (2022, 2025), whose key component to explain the distribution of *no* vs. the bare noun is the anti-uniqueness presupposition of the definite.

While quasi-names are a part of the definiteness puzzle, some pieces are still missing. The most pressing issue is that not all definite bare nouns seem to be quasi-names – as observed by Coppock and Bonney (2024): superlatives and functional nouns also appear without *no* (Owusu, 2022, 2025). Furthermore, much empirical work remains to be done with respect to the distribution of inanimate quasi-names and their scopal properties.

Beyond Akan, there are also general lessons for fieldwork. Definiteness questionnaires often diagnose uniqueness definites with the nouns *sun*, *chief* or *teacher* (see, for instance, Dawson and Jenks, 2023). In addition to Bangla and Cantonese, Akan is a further language which uses quasi-names in these cases. Thus, despite first appearances, titles and celestial objects may not be the best examples for uniqueness after all. It remains to be established how common this pattern is in Kwa languages and beyond – work which is left to future research.

¹³Ultimately, the quasi-name theory is also compatible with familiarity analyses of *no*, if one accepts that weak familiarity (rather than strong familiarity) is available for indexed definites. See Bombi (2018); Coppock (2022); Coppock and Bonney (2024) for the orthogonal discussion whether this is a desirable move.

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